GOV-01 · SOP Catalog Governance & Document Control

How the catalogue is numbered, owned, approved, reviewed and retired — and how the material that already exists is consolidated into it.

Field	Value
Document ID	GOV-01
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	D. Cross-Cutting Governance
Operating tier	Tier 4 — IT Management. Tier 4 owns every document in the catalogue, which keeps ownership in one place.
Review cycle	Annually.

1. Purpose

A catalogue without document control becomes the email threads it was built to replace. This document is the machinery that keeps it alive: how documents are numbered, who owns them, when they are reviewed, and how somebody proposes a change.

It also has a specific first task. Many organizations do not lack policy and procedure material — they lack a single index. Search the tenant for “standard operating procedure” and the material usually turns up in several places, with the IT policies missing from the page where people look for policies.

> **So this is a consolidation, not a creation**
> Section 9 is the consolidation worklist. It comes before writing anything new, because publishing a new catalogue alongside the existing partial ones would make the problem worse rather than better.

2. The two document types, and why both exist

Many service desks already keep a tier-based guide library. The catalogue is domain-based. These are different axes and both are correct — the mistake would be to force one into the other.

	SOP	Tier guide
Answers	What the organization’s procedure is.	What this tier does during a shift.
Organised by	Domain — M365, ACC, DEV, GOV.	Tier — one knowledge base folder per tier.

	SOP	Tier guide
Audience	Whoever must follow or approve the procedure. Often several tiers.	One tier, at the point of work.
Length	As long as the procedure needs.	Short. A guide that is not usable during a call is not a guide.
Authority	Authoritative. The SOP is the source.	Derived. A guide never contradicts its SOP; where it appears to, the SOP is right and the guide is a defect.
Lives in	The SOP library (§8).	The knowledge base, in its tier folder.
Example	ACC-04 Password Standard & Self-Service Password Reset.	Guide — Password Reset and Account Access (Tier 1).

One SOP may yield several guides — one per tier that touches it — plus an end-user article under GOV-05. All three derive from one source, which is what stops them drifting apart. A guide written independently of its SOP is the origin of every contradictory instruction a service desk has ever given.

3. Numbering

- Format: DOMAIN-nn. Domains are M365, ACC, DEV and GOV.
- Numbers are never reused and never renumbered. A retired document keeps its number and is marked retired, so that every reference in an older SOP, a ticket or an email still resolves.
- A new domain requires a Tier 4 decision. Four is deliberately few; a fifth should have to justify itself. Renumbering is the single most tempting and most damaging thing to do to a catalogue. It breaks every cross-reference at once, silently, and there is no way to detect the breakage except by reading everything.

4. Ownership and approval

Role	Responsibility
Contributing tier	The tier that operates the procedure. Consulted before approval and again at review — a procedure the operating tier has not read will not be followed.
Anybody	May propose a change (§10).

One owner and one approver per document. Shared ownership means no ownership, and a document with two owners is reviewed by neither.

5. The control block

Every document opens with one. It reuses the fields your knowledge base already uses, typically Version, Tier, Owner, Created and Review, and adds what a catalogue needs. Appendix A is the template.

Two fields are worth explaining because they are unusual and both earn their place:

- Cutover-sensitive. Says whether the document changes when a migration in flight completes. Where a document is, it carries a current-state and a target-state section rather than being rewritten later.
- Evidence base. Cites the observed items that justify the document. It is what lets any entry be defended in a budget or audit conversation, and it stops the catalogue accumulating documents nobody can remember the reason for.

6. Review cadence

Document class	Cadence	Also triggered by
Cutover-sensitive, migration live	Every 6 months	The cutover completing — at which point the current-state section is removed
Identity and security	Annually	Any attempted social-engineering incident; any change to Entra configuration
Everything else	Annually	A change to the system it describes
A document that produced a defect report	Immediately	Any report under §10 that the procedure did not work in practice

> **A document past its review date is flagged, not quietly trusted**
>
> Stale documentation is more dangerous than none, because people follow it. An expired SOP should be visibly expired in the register — the reader can then decide, rather than being misled.
>
> The register carries the review date for exactly this purpose, and a monthly check of overdue documents is a five-minute Tier 4 task.

7. Recording gaps — the most valuable convention in the catalogue

This convention is worth making standard, because it is unusually good practice.

> **What it looks like**
>
> Picture a Tier 1 password guide with a section headed “Gaps — read before using this on a live call”. It says plainly that identity verification is not documented anywhere, that this is the most important missing piece, and that it has been left blank rather than invented.
>
> That single paragraph is worth more than a confident answer would have been. It tells the next reader exactly what to build; in this catalogue, that is ACC-06.

So: every document in this catalogue may carry a Gaps section, and is expected to where gaps exist. The rules are short.

- State what is unknown, not a guess dressed as procedure. A guessed value that later proves wrong costs more than an acknowledged blank.
- Say what would be needed to close it, so it becomes a task rather than a complaint.

- Where a value must be confirmed from a live system, mark it and say so — as ACC-04 §3 does with the password policy.
- Gaps are reviewed at each review. A gap that has been open for two cycles is either not important or not resourced, and either answer is useful.

8. Where documents live

SOP library	A single SharePoint document library with versioning on, one folder per domain, and the register as its index. Approved documents as PDF alongside the editable source, so that the approved version cannot be edited by accident.
Tier guides	The knowledge base, one folder per tier. If that structure already exists and works, keep it.
End-user articles	The knowledge base, per GOV-05.
Organization policies	The staff portal's policies page, which is where people look. §9 makes sure the IT policies are actually linked there.
The register	The index. One row per document, with owner, approver, status, review date and operating tier.

9. Consolidating what already exists

In order, before new documents are added. Appendix B is the worklist.

1. Find out who has already begun. Look for existing workspaces, trackers or templates for SOP work. Where somebody has done work, duplicating it would be both wasteful and discouraging.
2. Inventory the existing published policies: the acceptable use policy, the information security policy (if it exists in more than one place, decide which copy is authoritative), and any other IT policies sitting in shared folders: network use, shared storage, sensitive data disposal, software acquisition, computer use, and email and accounts.
3. Map each existing policy to the catalogue entry that should align to it rather than replace it. Record each mapping in the register's Basis column.
4. Fix the staff portal's policies page. Policies often sit in a page's own asset folder with nothing linking to them. This is the cheapest visible win available and it requires no new writing.
5. Adopt the existing guide format and tier folders rather than inventing a parallel structure (§2).
6. Only then publish the register and begin the first phase of writing.

10. Change intake

1. Anybody may propose a change through the service desk against the document ID. No form, no committee — an ID and a sentence.
2. The owner responds within ten business days: accepted, accepted with modification, declined with a reason, or deferred to the next review with a date.
3. A report that a procedure turned out to be wrong in practice is a defect and takes priority over writing new documents. The register is worth nothing if people learn to work around it.

4. A change that alters a decision recorded in the document — a retention window, a naming convention, a service commitment — needs the approver, not just the owner.
5. Version increments: 0.x while draft, 1.0 on first approval, minor increment for clarification, major for a change in what the procedure requires.

11. Retirement

1. A document is retired when the system it describes is gone, or when it is superseded by another entry.
2. It keeps its number, is marked RETIRED with a date and a pointer to whatever replaced it, and stays in the library. It does not leave.
3. The register keeps the row. A reader following an old reference must be able to find out what happened rather than encountering nothing.
4. Retirement is an approver decision, recorded like any other.

12. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
The register	SOP library	Live — permanent
Approved PDF of every version	SOP library	Permanent
Change proposals and their outcomes	Ticket	3 years
Approver decisions on retention, naming and commitments	Document revision history	Permanent
Overdue-review log	IT governance record	3 years
Consolidation worklist outcomes (§9)	Project record	Life of the project + 2 years

13. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
Tier model	Your tiers and escalation guide	The tier model this catalogue attaches to. Not superseded.
GOV-05	Knowledge Base Article Standard	The derived end-user article format (§2).
GOV-06	Service Commitments, Priority & Escalation	Supplies the §10 response commitment.
GOV-02	Service Desk Intake, Ticket Quality & Categorisation	The intake channel §10 uses.
M365-10	SharePoint Site Request, Provisioning & Ownership	How the SOP library itself is provisioned and owned.
M365-16	Retention, Legal Hold & eDiscovery	Retention of approved documents.
All entries	Every document in the catalogue	This document governs all of them.

Appendix A — Control block template

Field	Guidance
Document ID	DOMAIN-nn. Never reused.
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	One of the four.
Operating tier	Which tier executes. Tier 4 owns regardless.
Review cycle	Per §6.
Related existing policy	Where an existing organization policy already covers this ground. Align, do not replace.
Closes / Gaps	What this document closes, and what it still cannot answer (§7).

Appendix B — Consolidation worklist

✓	Task	Where
☐	Find out who started the SOP work and how far it got	Existing workspaces, trackers and templates
☐	If the information security policy exists in more than one place, decide which copy is authoritative	Wherever the copies live
☐	Confirm the acceptable use policy is current, and whether any draft revision supersedes it	IT policies library
☐	Link every IT policy from the policies page	The staff portal
☐	Map each existing policy to its catalogue entry	Register — Basis column
☐	Adopt the existing guide format and tier folders	The knowledge base tier folders
☐	Provision the SOP library with versioning and domain folders	New SharePoint library (M365-10)
☐	Publish the register as its index	
☐	Then, and only then, start the first phase of writing	

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.